

SFK 2026 Summer Workshop Syllabus

Summary

The Game Design Intensive is a multi-week workshop taught by Peter Brinson, a Professor of Practice at the University of Southern California's games program. The Intensive is broken into three modules; the first module includes 5 online weekly workshops. A week later, the instructors and students meet in Shanghai for a 9-day rigorous preparation for the third module - a museum exhibition.

Aimed at students wanting to study game design, the classes will include lectures, workshops, and exercises. Design workshops are based on "Playcentric Design", an approach described and championed by USC professor, Tracy Fullerton's book, *Game Design Workshop*. Game production lectures are based on another USC professor's book, *Playful Production Process*, by Richard Lemarchand.

During Module 1, students work on their own, and during Modules 2 and 3, they work in teams. Each module involves crafting, prototyping, and iterating on video games based on their articulated goals and explorations. All games are structured forms of play, and the course will step students through the formal, dramatic, and systematic elements of digital games.

Not only will students' work add to their portfolio but - just as important - teams will develop portfolio-ready documentation of their design processes, which include designing, playtesting, evaluating, and iterating.

Recommended Unity Version: 6.4

Recommended Unreal Version: 5.7

Schedule

Module 1 - Online twice a week, focused on game design

Module 1, Day 1 - June 7

Lectures

- About The Instructor
 - Exploration vs Execution
 - Experience Goals
- Play: *Inside*.

Assignment for Day 2

- Assignment A: Write a 10-14 words video game premise for a single A game. The goal is to write one that creates anticipation: [your classmates and Professor] become inspired and excited to imagine what could happen in the game itself.

Consider today's lecture. Designed omission is productive.

[Put it here.](#)

- Assignment B: Watch 30 minutes of this:
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QOAW9ioWAvE>

Module 1, Day 2 - June 14

Lectures

- Classic Game Level Design: Metroid
- Research Games and Other Subjects
- "Single A Games"
- Catalysts of Speculation and Closure
- Creativity

Assignment for Day 3

- Assignment C: Write a second - and different - premise for a *single A game* considering our further discussions on Day 2. It can be 14 to 20 words. Perhaps it is 2 or 3 sentences. [Put it here.](#)
- Assignment D: List two topics that you learned in school or on your own that you wish were depicted in a game. **One** of them would make a good subject for a AAA game and the **other** for a single A game. In both cases, the topic should not be a common one depicted in games already. For example, World War II is a topic. So are the various battles in it. But such events have been depicted in video games a great many times, so it is not a good choice here. [Put it here.](#)

Module 1, Day 3 - June 21

Lectures

- Player Rewards
- Thinking Like a Player
- Complicated vs Complex
- Formal Elements of Games
- Luck, Skill, and Investment

Assignment for Day 4

- Assignment E: Think of 3 themes for a game jam. Here you will find the choices from 2009 to 2025, to help you understand what a theme is, under

“Event Themes”: [Wikipedia](#). Pretend you’re in charge of the Global Game Jam and it’s your job to think of the one for 2027. (Except I’m asking for 3). This is perfect for the Tortoise Mind. Put your answers [here](#).

Module 1, Day 4 - June 28

Lectures

- Game Production is:
- Method and Agile
- Game Design Macro
- Concentric Development
- Playtesting

Assignment for Day 5

- Assignment F: List one game that is natural for concentric design. And one that is not. Write them [here](#).

Module 1, Day 5 - July 4

Lectures

- Collaboration and Playtesting
- [Terminology and Use](#)
- Preparing for Module 2 (see below)
- Closing Advice

Module 2 - In person, focused on game production

Module 2, Day 1 - The Museum

July 16 - Mazes & Situations

A theory of worldbuilding.

- [Situational Game Design](#)
- [Labyrinths: Design Axes](#)
- [Backrooms](#), Zelda
- Workshop: paper labyrinths
- The Tortoise Mind, Hare Brain
- Classic Games’ Situations. And The Museum
- Labyrinths: [3 kinds](#)
- [Consistency and Internal Logic](#)
- [Assignment A - Playable Maze](#)

Module 2, Day 2 - SFK Classroom

July 17 - Preproduction

Ideas Are More Important Than Productivity, For Now

- [Bounded Worlds](#) — Finite / Closed / Threshold
- [The Game Engine Tutor](#) (an AI tool). [Chinese Version](#)
- [The Traveler, World as Presence](#)
- [Building Imaginary Worlds](#)
- Experience Goals

Module 2, Day 3 - SFK Classroom

July 20 - Production

- Core Principles
- Workflow
- Documentation
- Vertical Slice

Module 2, Day 4 - SFK Classroom

July 21 - Production

- Documentation (continued)

Module 2, Day 5 - SFK Classroom

July 22 - PostProduction

- Polish and Delivery
- Video Documentation

Module 3 - Museum Exhibition

Module 3, Day 1 - The Museum

July 23 - Exhibition, Preparation

Module 3, Day 2 - The Museum

July 24 - Exhibition